

Change Is a Must: From Shy Tomboy to Coaching Legend, Featuring Steve Olson

Steve Olson, Distinguished Lecturer, UT Chattanooga

“As badly as I wanted to become someone new, I resisted saying it aloud. I viewed it as a sign of weakness if I had changed. Today, if someone tells me that I’ve changed, I take it as a compliment.”

Pat Summitt’s teams won because Pat Summitt changed. Pat Summitt’s teams won so much because Pat Summitt changed so much. Pat knew that it was impossible to win the national championship if she didn’t change. Change is a must. But it wasn’t going to do any good if only she changed. She had to inspire, motivate, and teach her players and assistants to change. And she knew that in order to repeat as national champions, she would have to change again and again and again.

Pat’s eight national championship teams and her lifetime winning percentage bear testimony to the timeless wisdom of her ***Definite Dozen*** principles, but none more so than ***Change is a must***. Pat’s story is so simple and surprising and its implications so profound, it bears retelling. Pat was a farm girl. When she arrived at college, she was so shy and modest that she dressed herself in her closet. But she finally decided she was tired of being known as the “5-foot-11 tomboy.”

Coach Pat Summitt

You probably won’t believe this, but I was incredibly shy. I was shy with my peers. And actually, I joined a sorority, which no one would ever think that I would be the sorority girl type. I think that is one of the best things that happened to me. My sorority sisters made fun of my clothes. I didn’t wear makeup, and they were going to give me a makeover and change my wardrobe. And, you know, it was tough for me because, you know, I just basically surrendered to a group of people and said, “Okay, here I am.” That really had a big influence on my life and just kind of taught me the ropes because I’d pretty much been on the on the dairy farm all my life.

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In fact, she changed so much that her friends back home commented on it. She’d react defensively and deny it, of course; but deep down, she knew that they were right. She had changed. And what’s more, she liked who she was becoming. So, she determined that while she would stay true to who she was and where she came from, she would also commit to growing professionally for the rest of her life; and that’s just what Pat Summitt did.